

WIDOWED CHILDREN

Primitive customs rooted in deprivation have given us child marriage, and worse, the widowhood of many of these little girls. There are thousands of child widows in the villages of the desert state, strangled forever by fate, leading lives of social anonymity they had no choice to reject.

■ By Rohit Parihar

Eight-year-old Suman Teli lives in Pander village of Rajasthan's Bhilwara district. Skipping through Pander's dusty streets on her way to school, past terracotta-roofed mud and brick houses, Suman could well be just one of the millions of faceless children in the great rural beyond. But she isn't. Suman is a widow. A widow studying in Class II, a widow for the past three years, and a widow for the rest of her life.

Suman is not the only one. In the same village, lives Shanti Khati, all of 10 years old, and widow for the last three years. Shanti became a widow at seven when her husband Bheru Khati, of village Mataji ka Khera, drowned in a pond. Shanti does not go to school; she's busy working in the fields and with household chores.

NATHI KUMAWAT, 20
Married at 4, widowed at 8,
Sheopura village, Ajmer



It's a tale told thousands of times across Rajasthan; 5,081 times in the 10-14 age group, and 8,244 times in the 15-19 age group, according to the 2001 census. Across India, the figure grows into a numbing 1,07,993 for the 10-14 age group, and 1,27,003 for the 15-19 group. What's missing in the census report is a mention of widows less than nine years of age. INDIA TODAY found some. And it wasn't so difficult.

Suman and Shanti are victims of child marriage, their misfortune compounded by the deaths of their child-husbands. Suman's grandfather Mohan Teli wanted to witness his six-year-old grandson Sunil's marriage. A match was found, but the would-be bride's family wanted a bride in exchange, for their eight-year-old Mukesh. Sunil's elder sister Maya was older than Mukesh, so five-year-old Suman it had to be. Grandfather Mohan died in peace but, months later, Suman was widowed when a brain ailment claimed Mukesh.

Suman, back with her parents after the wedding, was rushed to her in-laws for the widowhood ceremonies. The bangles on her fragile wrists were broken, her bindi wiped away. "Yes, something like this was done," she remembers vaguely. What she still can't understand is why the bangles were broken, or why she's been kept away from religious ceremonies and social gatherings.

Shanti has a similar life, and parallel questions. She's been told to stay aloof. "I wonder why I am not allowed to ride the swings on Teej like other girls," she says.

Bad as it is for these child widows, life only gets worse when they get older. That's when they are 'remarried'. This custom, known as 'nata' among the agrarian low-caste communities that practice it, gives these girls a colourless wedding and a live-in relationship; a legal marriage but social apartheid. A child widow rarely gets any share in her first husband's property, and for the parents, it's an additional burden to marry her off again. "It's ironical that many justify child marriage as a means to escape expenses whereas early widowhood brings back the burden of raising the girl